Publishing a note

NSDF-Data student guide 4 — for every computer

Version 9 · 13 October 2026

Tip

This is guide 4 of 5. It is about getting a finished note onto the site. Guide 3 covers writing the note; guide 5 covers doing this with an AI assistant.

What happens when you publish

Your note goes through four stages. You do the first two, the automatic check does the third, and your lead does the fourth:

1. **You** write the note as a `.md` file in the `notes/src/` folder, on your own branch.
2. **You** open a **pull request**: a request to add your work to the project.
3. **The check** runs at once. It lists anything wrong with the note.
4. **Your lead** reviews the note, gives it a note number (the next free one, for example 8), and merges it. After the merge the site builds your page. This takes a few minutes.

Nothing reaches the public site until the merge.

Before you start

- **You have write access.** Your lead adds you to the project on GitHub. You need this to push a branch.
- **Your note is written and checked** against guide 3, as a Markdown file (the VS Code route) or a Word or Google Docs file, and the notebook it uses is committed to your branch.
- **You know your branch name.** It is `student-yourname`, from the setup guide.

Step 1. Get your note into `notes/src/`

Your note has to end up as a Markdown file in the `notes/src/` folder, with its pictures in `notes/src/img/`. Follow the part that matches how you wrote it.

If you wrote Markdown in VS Code

The note is already in place. Check that:

- the note is `notes/src/your-note-name.md`, started from `_template.md`, with the header kept;
- every picture is a file directly in `notes/src/img/` (not in a subfolder), named with your note's name at the start, and linked as `img/your-note-name-fig1.png`;

- the template's line that points to `img/example.png` is deleted or replaced by one of your own pictures. The check reports a missing picture otherwise.

If you wrote in Word or Google Docs

A small program in the project, `tools/word_to_note.py`, turns the document into a note and saves its pictures in the right place under the right names.

a. Export the document.

- In **Word**: **File**, then **Save As**, and choose **Word Document (.docx)**.
- In **Google Docs**: **File**, then **Download**, then **Microsoft Word (.docx)**.

Save it in your `Research` folder, next to `NSDF-Data`, as `my-note.docx`.

b. Install pandoc once. In the terminal, with your environment active:

```
conda activate darkmatter_cli_env
conda install -c conda-forge pandoc -y
```

On macOS you can also use `brew install pandoc`. On Windows, the pandoc website has an installer.

c. Convert. In the terminal, go to the `NSDF-Data` folder and run (change `my-note.docx` and choose a note name made of lowercase letters and hyphens):

```
python tools/word_to_note.py ../my-note.docx your-note-name
```

It writes `notes/src/your-note-name.md`. It saves each picture in `notes/src/img/` as `your-note-name-fig1.png`, then `-fig2.png`, and so on, in the order the pictures appear. It fixes the links and tells you what it did.

Checkpoint

The program printed `Wrote notes/src/your-note-name.md` and the number of pictures you expect. Open the note in VS Code or any text editor. Every section title you styled as a heading should start with # or ##, and every picture should be a line starting `![` with a caption line under it. If the program listed leftover formatting (`<u>`, `<sup>`, `<sub>`, `<span>`), delete those tags and keep the words, or the check will reject the note. If you see no # lines at all, your titles were not Heading-styled: fix the document and run the command again.

d. Fill in the header at the top of the new note: title, author, date, keywords and the one-sentence description (guide 3, *The header*). Leave `id: "TBD"`.

Tip

Test the conversion before you rely on it. Convert a short two-section document with one picture first. If the headings and the picture both come through, convert the real note.

Your lead will replace `id: "TBD"` with a number.

Step 2. Commit to your branch

In the terminal, from the `NSDF-Data` folder:

```
git checkout student-yourname
```

```
git add notes/src/your-note-name.md notes/src/img
git status
git commit -m "Add note: your title"
git push -u origin student-yourname
```

Checkpoint

Look at the list that `git status` prints before the commit. It should contain only your note and its pictures. If it shows `.bin` files, anything from the `idx` folder, or changes to other people's notes, stop and ask your lead.

Step 3. Open the pull request

Tip

What is a pull request? Nothing scary. Your branch is your own copy of the project. Nothing you do on it changes anyone else's work or the public site. A *pull request* is a button on github.com that means "I'm done, please have a look." Your lead reads it, may ask for changes, and only then adds your work to the project. Until then you can push as often as you like, and you cannot break anything. If something looks wrong, stop, type `git status`, and send your lead what it prints. Guide 8, *Git in five minutes*, explains the words and the few commands you need.

On github.com, open the repository. GitHub shows a yellow banner saying your branch had recent pushes. Click **Compare & pull request**. Check that:

- the **base** is `develop` and the **compare** branch is `student-yourname`;
- the title says what the note is about;
- the description says, in one sentence, what question the note answers;
- if your note replaces an earlier note, the description says so (for example `Supersedes Note 3`).

Click **Create pull request**.

Careful

If your note replaces an earlier note, that note's status must change and it must link to yours, and this has to travel in the same pull request. Guide 3 (*If your note replaces an earlier note*) says what goes in your note. For a hand-written note, your lead adds the change as a commit on your branch, so you do not edit `docs/`. For another student note, include its changed file in your pull request.

Step 4. Read the check

The check starts automatically and takes less than a minute. When it finishes, click **Details** on the check, and read its messages. Each message names the file and the problem. Here are the common ones and what to do:

Message says	What to do
`header field 'X' is missing or empty`	Fill in that line of the header.
`status must be one of ...`	Use exactly *In progress*, *Complete* or *Superseded (reference/link)*.
`id must be a note number such as 8 ... or TBD`	Leave `id: "TBD"`.
`raw HTML tag <u>` (or `<sup>`, `<sub>`, `<span>`)	Remove the formatting and keep the words.
`notebook link pinned to 'master'`	Replace `master` with the commit hash you committed the notebook at.
`placeholder COMMIT is still in the note`	Put the real commit hash in place of `COMMIT`.
`picture not found`	Check the file name and that the picture is in `notes/src/img/`.
`picture '...' must be directly in notes/src/img/`	Move the picture out of the subfolder into `notes/src/img/` and link it as `img/name.png`. A note made with `word_to_note.py` already does this.

To fix a problem: edit the file on your branch and commit again. The pull request updates itself, and the check runs again.

Tip

If the check passes, the structure is right. It cannot tell whether your numbers are right or your reading is fair. Check those yourself, and ask your lead if you are unsure.

Step 5. Wait for review

Your lead reads the note, may comment on the pull request, and may ask you for changes. Answer each comment in the pull request. When the note is ready, your lead gives it a number and merges it.

After the merge

- The site builds your page automatically, usually within two minutes. Check the front page: your note appears in the **Analysis Notes** table, in order of its note number.
- The page is at `notes/student-<name>.html` on the site.

Changing a note later

You can change a published note either way you wrote it. Start from the latest version of your branch. Your lead gave your note its number on the pull request, and your own copy of the file may still say `TBD`:

```
git switch student-yourname
git pull origin develop
```

Open `notes/src/your-note-name.md` and look at the header. It should say your note's number, for example `id: "8"`. **Keep that number.** If it says `TBD`, stop and ask your lead: the check does not mind `TBD`, but the site cannot publish a note with it, and nothing is published until it is fixed.

Then choose **one** of the two ways and keep to it, because the second one replaces the text of the note:

Way 1. Edit the Markdown. Open `notes/src/your-note-name.md` in VS Code (or any text editor), change the text, and replace a picture by saving the new PNG under the same name in `notes/src/img/`.

Way 2. Edit the Word or Google Docs file. Change the document, export it again as a `.docx` (Step 1a), and run the same command with the **same note name**:

```
python tools/word_to_note.py ../my-note.docx your-note-name
```

The program replaces the text and the pictures, and **keeps your header as it is**, so the number stays. Pictures are numbered in the order they appear, so the file names can shift if you add one in the middle; the links are rewritten to match, and pictures that are no longer used are removed. Do not edit the Markdown by hand in this way: the next run would overwrite your changes.

After either way, update the **date** line, and the **Status** line if the conclusion has changed, in the header. Look at what changed before you commit:

```
git status
git diff notes/src/your-note-name.md
```

Then commit, push, and open a new pull request (or add to the open one). Let the check run again. If a result was wrong, say so in the note, with the date, as guide 3 explains. Do not delete a published note to hide a mistake.

Session Info

Guide version 9, 13 October 2026. Written for every computer. Please tell the project lead where a step was unclear.

Where to get help

Anthony Villano, project lead: anthony.villano@ucdenver.edu

When you write, include the pull request number, the message the check gave, and the step you are stuck on.

Key links

- Pull requests: https://github.com/villano-lab/NSDF-Data/pulls
- Notes site: https://villano-lab.github.io/NSDF-Data/
- Repository: https://github.com/villano-lab/NSDF-Data